

INTRODUCTION

EDITORIAL POLICY

The Visual Dictionary takes an inventory of the physical environment of a person who is part of today's technological age and who knows and uses a large number of specialized terms in a wide variety of fields.

Designed for the general public, it responds to the needs of anyone seeking the precise, correct terms for a wide range of personal or professional reasons: finding an unknown term, checking the meaning of a word, translation, advertising, teaching material, etc.

The target user has guided the choice of contents for *The Visual Dictionary*, which aims to bring together in 12 thematic books the technical terms required to express the contemporary world, in the specialized fields that shape our daily experience.

STRUCTURE

Each tome has three sections: the preliminary pages, including the table of contents; the body of the text (i.e. the detailed treatment of the theme); the index.

Information is presented moving from the most abstract to the most concrete: sub-theme, title, subtitle, illustration, terminology.

TERMINOLOGY

Each word in *The Visual Dictionary* has been carefully selected following examination of high-quality documentation, at the required level of specialization.

There may be cases where different terms are used to name the same item. In such instances, the word most frequently used by the most highly regarded authors has been chosen.

Words are usually referred to in the singular, even if the illustration shows a number of individual examples. The word designates the concept, not the actual illustration.

DEFINITIONS

Within the hierarchical format of *The Visual Dictionary*'s presentation, the definitions fit together like a Russian doll. For example, the information within the definition for the term *insect* at the top of the page does not have to be repeated for each of the insects illustrated. Instead, the text concentrates on defining the distinguishing characteristics of each insect (the *louse* is a parasite, the female *yellow jacket* stings, and so forth).

Since the definition leaves out what is obvious from the illustration, the illustrations and definitions complement one another.

The vast majority of the terms in the *Visual Dictionary* are defined. Terms are not defined when the illustration makes the meaning absolutely clear, or when the illustration suggests the usual meaning of the word (for example, the numerous *handles*).

METHODS OF CONSULTATION

Users may gain access to the contents of *The Visual Dictionary* in a variety of ways:

- From the TABLE OF CONTENTS at the end of the preliminary pages, the user can locate by title the section that is of interest.
- With the INDEX, the user can consult *The Visual Dictionary* from a word, so as to see what it corresponds to, or to verify accuracy by examining the illustration that depicts it.
- The most original aspect of *The Visual Dictionary* is the fact that the illustrations enable the user to find a word even if he or she only has a vague idea of what it is. The dictionary is unique in this feature, as consultation of any other dictionary requires the user first to know the word.